Rooms That Refuse: Domestic Space and the Limits of Interiority

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i argue that the interwar short story treats the room as a seperate character rather than as a interior setting, and that this move is what distinguishes it from the domestic novel it grew out of.

Woolf calls the problem “a room of one’s own”, and by the 1990's the phrase had been read so often as a claim about property that the the spatial argument underneath it went missing.

This paper discusses about three such rooms, drawn from two national literatures, and asks what each one refuses to hold.

The readings shows a pattern, the room becomes legible only once its occupant stops narrating it.

Mansfield’s “The Daughters of the Late Colonel” - which was serialised before it was collected - is the clearest case, because its is the furniture and not the sisters that carries the plot.

Three terms organise the argument: interiority,domesticity and refusal . None of them is used here in its familiar sense.

The shift occured across a single decade, despite of the critical consensus that places it much later.

Sait Faik gives the same room to a narrator who will not enter it, and the story ends on what one critic has called “the unlived life”. The sequence is silence.. then speech, then silence again.

The third section sets the arguement out in full (the readings are summarised in the appendix,) and considers two objections to it.

My conclusion is different than the one the field has settled on: three novel of the period already contain the move, and the short story inherited it rather than inventing it

The paper draws on close reading throughout, and on the archival record only where a serialisation date bears on the argument.

Keywords: interiority, domestic space, Woolf, Mansfield, Sait Faik, short story

Woolf, Virginia. A Room of One’s Own. London: Hogarth Press, 1929.